

PE

waiting for the RSS man to deliver

The Bloopers

The BJP chief has rolled on from one controversy to another

In the Doghouse

Gadkari's remark, comparing the Mulayam-Lalu duo to dogs licking the feet of Congress President Sonia Gandhi, ended hopes of building on opposition unity seen during price rise protests.

Jharkhand Fiasco

Gadkari's persistent efforts to form a government in Jharkhand at any cost showed the party in poor light, coming across as power hungry, causing loss of face.

Devil's Advocate

Gave a clean chit to the Congress for its role in the 1984 riots in an interview to BBC. Later showed ignorance while defending Modi's role in the 2002 riots.

Dilly-dallying

Instead of a man of action, he is showing himself to be a reluctant doer. First, he took inordinately long to announce his team and now has not assigned responsibility to it.

Jai Maharashtra

Lacks a national outlook. His political experience having been limited to Vidarbha and being chief of Maharashtra unit as a junior alliance partner, he is comfortable with Marathi-speaking aides.

office at 11, Ashok Road, it will probably take him some time to acquire a national outlook. The predominant conversation in the national president's office is conducted in Marathi.

In fact, his lack of national experience is cited as an excuse even for his "dog" remark made in reference to Mulayam Singh Yadav and Lalu Prasad Yadav. Party spokesperson Nirmala Sitharaman was at pains to explain that in Vidarbha, from where Gadkari comes, such usage was not really considered abusive. Party insiders say that Gadkari is prone to using colourful language and got carried away at the Chandigarh rally, where he made the comparison between the Yadav duo and dogs, but it has come back to bite him where it hurts. "Something like this can be expected from a Samajwadi Party or a Bahujan Samaj Party leader. Coming from the BJP president, it is completely unacceptable," said one of his detractors in the party.

Indeed, even his most ardent supporters are running out of excuses now. The man who fainted at his first biggest event—the *Sansad Chalo* rally against price rise in the Capital on April 21—is at the risk of losing his image of a dynamic doer. First, he took nearly three months to put together and announce his team of office-bearers, which was as lacklustre as it could get. He failed to introduce any new energy into the team. Now, more than two months later, he is still to assign any work to them. This, from the man who hoped to run the party like a corporate house. One of the first things he had done after taking over as party president was to gift a desktop placard to everyone in the BJP central office, that said, "I like people who can get things done". The white and gold placard was "with best compliments" from him. "All this is very well but people have to know what they are expected to do. Only then things will get done," says one of the office-bearers, still waiting for work to be assigned to him.

The latest promise is that work will be assigned to them before the party's national executive in Patna on June 12 and 13. Till then, instead of building the party, the office-bearers are left twid-

dling their thumbs. Some people have been unofficially told what is expected from them. Party secretary Navjot Singh Sidhu, for example, has been asked to get more youth into the party. Other secretaries Vani Tripathi and Smriti Irani have been given the task of attracting right-thinking women to the party. Another secretary, Murlidhar Rao, who has headed the Swadeshi Jagran Manch in the most trying times, has been told to organise things. It is as vague as it gets. Despite his emphasis on attracting the youth, he is still to appoint someone as the president of the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha.

"Give him time," is the constant refrain of his aides and supporters. "He is taking time because he wants to assign the best man for the specific job.

The man who fainted at his first big event, the *Sansad Chalo* rally, against price rise in the Capital on April 21 is at risk of losing his image of a dynamic doer.

He is talking to everyone and is interacting with people all over the country. Also, he has his own ideas about things and there is pressure from others in the party. He has to find a balance between the two," explains an aide.

However, there are no explanations and excuses for the way Gadkari blundered on Jharkhand. When the party's Parliamentary Board decided to withdraw support from the Shibu Soren-led government after he voted against the Opposition's Cut Motion, Gadkari put the decision on hold. He persisted on holding discussions with the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) in the hope of leading a government in the state. After a month-long drama—aptly described as the "theatre of the absurd" by senior party leader Murli Manohar Joshi—the BJP finally withdrew support on May 24, causing a